

NEIGHBOURS

PAKISTAN



Musharraf is History

THE FORMER PRESIDENT LEAVES BEHIND A COUNTRY FACING SOME OF ITS STIFFEST CHALLENGES IN HISTORY. THE COALITION GOVERNMENT IS ALREADY FRACTURING, THE ECONOMY IS IN A TAILSPIN AND EXTREMIST FORCES ARE GAINING ASCENDANCY.

■ By Raj Chengappa in Islamabad and Hasan Zaidi in Karachi

Stripped of the strapping of power, Pervez Musharraf looked very much the army pensioner wearing a fresh cotton shirt and discussing his game of tennis with visitors who dropped by to see him at the President's Lodge in Rawalpindi on August 20. Just two days before, President General (retired) Musharraf was the most powerful man in Pakistan or so he believed. Now the man who had made so much history in the past nine years was, well, history. He seemed to accept that his days of being on centre-stage were over and told a friend, "I want to be on the sidelines now and not meddle with politics." Till the afternoon of August 18 when he announced his resignation over national television, few believed that Musharraf would throw in the towel. He had proven to be a great survivor despite the many political setbacks and assassination attempts since he grabbed power in a bloodless army coup in 1999. He had even boasted that like a cat he believed he had nine lives—possibly even more. But for Musharraf the writing had been on the wall ever since his opponents stormed back to power in the February general elections. Only he didn't



MOVING ON: Musharraf receiving the ceremonial send off after his resignation on August 18

GENERAL MUSHARRAF'S DEPARTURE HAS BROUGHT INTO SHARP FOCUS